



The Record Behind the Bolt

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 On June 4 a Lufthansa Dreamliner sat at gate A15 in Frankfurt with its nose on the tarmac. The jet was five months old. It had flown 137 times. A locking pin meant to hold the nose gear down had been set in the wrong position, and the gear folded while the plane was being readied for Los Angeles. Two cabin crew and several ground workers were taken to the hospital before a single passenger had boarded.

2 The pin itself was a maintenance mistake, and a British Airways 787 collapsed the same way at Heathrow in 2021 for the same reason. That much Boeing can set aside. What it cannot set aside is the record that was already on file when the gear gave way, a record the public had been told would be managed.

3 Three months before Frankfurt, the FAA proposed mandatory inspections of every 787 in the fleet for fatigue cracks at the splice plates where the wing joins the body: gaps past the engineering limit, preload past what the fasteners were built to bear, cracks waiting at the bolt holes [Asyndeton]. Boeing kept delivering the airplanes. In 2024 the agency audited the company for six weeks and watched it fail thirty-three of eighty-nine checks, most of them on the manufacturing controls meant to keep exactly this from happening. The line kept moving. That same year Boeing conceded its South Carolina workers had falsified inspection records on wing-to-body joins, and a federal memo found contaminated composite on more than a thousand Dreamliners, some bonded below the strength the design required.

4 Set the two columns side by side. In one, a paper trail of cracks, falsified records, contaminated parts, and audits failed. In the other, the same jets rolling off the line and into the gates, carrying the people who never saw the file. [Antithesis]

5 When a regulator lets each audit stand alone with no data tying them together, when the company it watches cuts roughly nine hundred quality inspectors in two years and the agency's own inspector general reports that nobody tracks whether the same violations keep recurring, the question stops being whether another part will fail. [Cumulative and periodic sentences] It becomes which one, and when, and who is standing under it.

6 Who answers for a risk that was written down, costed out, and waved through? [Rhetorical question]

7 The nose gear at Frankfurt is one bolt set wrong on one morning. The record behind it is years of warnings managed by press release. We are the passengers in the second column. We hold the vote, the hearing, the contract, the attention [Parallelism] that decides whether a documented danger gets fixed or gets filed. The plane was new. [Telegraphic sentence] Make them answer for the rest.

Devices, and why they are here:

Asyndeton (paragraph 3): “gaps past the engineering limit, preload past what the fasteners were built to bear, cracks waiting at the bolt holes”

Dropping the conjunctions from the shim gap findings (gaps, preload, cracks) packs the engineering failures into one fast, breathless pile, so the danger reads as a list that keeps going rather than a tidy, finished set. The speed mimics defects accumulating faster than anyone closes them out.

Antithesis (paragraph 4): “In one, a paper trail of cracks, falsified records, contaminated parts, and audits failed. In the other, the same jets rolling off the line and into the gates, carrying the people who never saw the file.”

This is the engine of the whole piece: the documented record set in balanced opposition against the planes still rolling into service. Holding the two columns in one matched construction forces the reader to see them as a single fact, not two separate stories, which is the accountability claim in miniature.

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 5): “When a regulator lets each audit stand alone with no data tying them together, when the company it watches cuts roughly nine hundred quality inspectors in two years and the agency’s own inspector general reports that nobody tracks whether the same violations keep recurring, the question stops being whether another part will fail.”

The long sentence withholds its main clause behind two stacked when-clauses about the regulator and the company, loading the systemic context first so that the point, that the only open question is which part fails next, lands with maximum weight at the end. The suspended build carries the suspension without any dash.

Rhetorical question (paragraph 6): “Who answers for a risk that was written down, costed out, and waved through?”

A single indicting question placed at the pivot, after the record is laid out and before the charge. It is not asked for an answer but to corner one: a written-down, costed-out, waved-through risk demands a named party, and the absence of one is the indictment.

Parallelism (paragraph 7): “the vote, the hearing, the contract, the attention”

The matched noun phrases (the vote, the hearing, the contract, the attention) sit mid-clause, not at the head, naming the concrete levers the public actually holds. Listing them in parallel turns a vague civic duty into countable instruments and sets up the charge to use them.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 7): “The plane was new.”

Four flat words, The plane was new, dropped just before the final charge. The clipped line strips the argument back to the one fact that makes the record damning and throws the weight onto the command that follows it.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the fourth paragraph (the two columns) and the fifth paragraph (the regulator and the inspectors) is best described as one in which the writer first

- A) concedes that the maintenance error was unavoidable and then withdraws the charge against the manufacturer
- B) predicts a future accident and then supplies the statistics that have already confirmed it
- C) sets the documented failures against continued production and then names the oversight gaps that let the contradiction persist
- D) contrasts Boeing with its regulator and then argues the regulator is the more culpable of the two

2. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's tone across the final paragraph?
- A) Resigned pessimism that treats further accidents as beyond anyone's control
 - B) Detached neutrality that lays out the failures without taking a side
 - C) Measured indictment that hands the reader a duty to act
 - D) Sweeping outrage that condemns commercial aviation as a whole

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer C. Paragraph four holds the paper trail of defects against the jets still entering service; paragraph five explains the missing data practices and the cut inspectors that allow that gap to continue, moving from the contradiction to its enabling conditions. The option about an unavoidable error and a withdrawn charge inverts the passage, which never excuses Boeing. The option about predicting a future accident misreads paragraph five, where the writer says only the timing is unknown rather than offering confirming statistics. The option that ranks the regulator as more culpable imports a comparison the passage does not make, since it faults both without weighing one against the other.

2. Answer C. The close stays controlled, restating the single fact that the plane was new and then issuing a direct charge to make them answer, which is indictment delivered as obligation rather than vented anger. The detached-neutrality option ignores the explicit command that ends the piece. The resigned-pessimism option contradicts the call to use the vote, the hearing, and the contract, which assumes the outcome can still change. The sweeping-outrage option overstates the target, since the writer charges one company and its specific oversight, not the industry at large.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer separates the nose gear pin (a maintenance error) from the manufacturing record (cracks, falsified inspections, contaminated parts) and insists the two are not the same problem. Why open with the incident that is not Boeing's manufacturing fault before turning to the failures that are? What does that sequence buy the argument?
2. The piece never says the shim gap defect caused the Frankfurt collapse, and in fact denies any link. How does the writer build a charge of accountability without claiming the documented defects caused this specific accident, and is that a fair move or an unfair one?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. Opening on the pin lets the writer concede the one thing the reader might already know, that this looks like simple human error with a clear precedent at Heathrow, and clear it off the table before it can be used as an excuse. By granting that the collapse itself was a maintenance mistake, the writer earns the right to say the real issue lies elsewhere, in the filed record. The sequence disarms the easy defense first, so the turn to the manufacturing failures reads as fair rather than as piling on.
2. The argument works by holding two true things side by side rather than by asserting cause. The writer lays out the documented defects, the failed audits, the falsified records, and the cut inspectors, and sets them against the fact that the planes kept being built and flown. The charge is not that shim gaps folded the gear; it is that a company operating with this record had no business treating any safety question as managed. That is defensible because the moral claim is about known risk inadequately controlled, not about a single causal chain, though a skeptical reader could argue the juxtaposition still invites the causal inference the writer formally disowns.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that an organization can be held accountable for a pattern of documented, inadequately managed risk even when that pattern did not cause the specific failure in front of the public. Write an essay in which you defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that accountability for known risk does not depend on proving that the known risk caused the particular harm. Use evidence from your own reading, observation, study, or experience to support your line of reasoning.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the piece as claiming the shim gap wing defect caused the nose gear collapse. The writer explicitly denies this and even calls the pin a maintenance mistake; the argument is about an accumulated record of risk, not a single cause. Watch for essays that invent a causal link the text refuses to make.
- Students often label the matched noun phrases in the last paragraph (the vote, the hearing, the contract, the attention) as anaphora. They are parallelism: the repeated structure sits inside the clause, not at the start of successive clauses. Anaphora would require the same word opening consecutive sentences.
- Students may treat the rhetorical question in paragraph six as a genuine request for information or as the writer admitting uncertainty. It is an indicting question placed at the pivot; it presumes there should be an answer and exposes that none has been given. Mark the whole question as the move, not the word Who.
- Students may mistake the two-column paragraph for false balance or both-sidesing. It is antithesis driving a one-sided argument: the two columns are not weighed as equal positions but set against each other so the contradiction between them becomes the charge.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches how a writer builds an accountability argument through structure rather than accusation: a single sustained antithesis (documented risk against continued production) carried from the columns paragraph through the close, an indicting rhetorical question at the pivot, and a periodic sentence that withholds its point to land it hard. It gives students a clean case for distinguishing parallelism from anaphora, for seeing how asyndeton and a telegraphic sentence control pace, and for analyzing how a charge can be fair even when the writer disclaims a causal link, which makes it strong material for both Q2 rhetorical analysis and the Q3 argument prompt on accountability for known risk.